Workbook

on Supporting the Mental Health and Psychosocial Wellbeing of Young Changemakers

unicef
for every child



This workbook belongs to .....

This workbook is intended to be used alongside the UNICEF *Training Toolkit on Supporting the Mental Health and Psychosocial Wellbeing of Young Changemakers*, which provides the roadmap for skilled facilitators to deliver an online training to young changemakers to equip them with the knowledge, skills, and supports to protect and promote their mental health and psychosocial wellbeing.

The resource has two parts:

A **Facilitators' Guide** consisting of a virtual training script and accompanying slides for the delivery of a 2-day, 8-hour (4 hours per day) interactive, experiential training to young changemakers; and

This **workbook** to be used by young changemakers during the training, and to be a personal resource for participants on promoting their mental health and psychosocial wellbeing.

Helplines accessible to me: .....
(find one here: https://findahelpline.com/)

A friend with whom I can connect in times of distress: .....

A trustworthy adult around me who can be open to listening to me: .....

Resources that work for me in providing emotional support: .....

My Mental Health and Wellbeing Diary: My Workbook on How to Champion Causes while Championing Yourself

Young changemakers tackling today's interconnected challenges—from climate change to social inequality, political polarization to global health crises—face a unique set of pressures.

This workbook is a dedicated space designed specifically for young changemakers like yourself as you navigate this immensely gratifying and complex world of changemaking. This workbook has been designed to be interactive and goes hand-in-hand with the *Training Toolkit on Supporting the Mental Health and Psychosocial Wellbeing of Young Changemakers*. Here, you'll have the space to explore how to best develop and utilize tools for your mental health toolbox through guided reflective practices, explore your emotional strengths further, and identify areas where support can be helpful. Any content labeled 'Extension' is an activity that goes beyond what is used in the training, and is intended to provide you with additional resources to support your mental health toolbox.

We hope this resource offers a space for you to complement and continue the learning process initiated by the training, and dive deeper into some of the essential components of supporting your mental health and psychosocial wellbeing as a changemaker.

In creating this workbook, we acknowledge the work of young changemakers who, through their vulnerabilities and resilience, have shaped these spaces for us.



Making This Workbook Uniquely Yours

This interactive workbook offers:

- **Content** that reinforces important information and reminders from your training
- **Practices** that engage you in active learning, reflection, and skill-building
- **Tools** to build your personalized toolkit for long-term wellbeing strategies that you can adapt to your unique needs

Each section invites exploration rather than prescribing rigid rules. Feel free to make notes, doodle, and highlight what resonates with you—this is your space to be authentic and discover what works best for you. Everything here can be customized to fit your life and priorities. Take what resonates, adapt what needs adjustment, and create strategies that work for your unique situation. Return to these pages whenever you need a reminder or want to try something new.

What This Workbook is Not

It's important to clarify what this workbook isn't designed to be. This resource serves as a companion to—not a replacement for—the complete training program, offering supplementary guidance rather than comprehensive coverage of all training materials. The practices and suggestions within these pages are invitations for exploration, not rigid rules or requirements that must be followed precisely. Most critically, while this workbook provides valuable self-care strategies and reflection tools, it cannot and should not substitute for professional mental health support when needed. If you're experiencing persistent distress or significant mental health challenges, we encourage you to reach out to qualified mental health professionals who can provide the specialized care you deserve.



The Inner Atlas:
Mapping Mental Health and Psychosocial Wellbeing

Mental health encompasses people's emotional, psychological and social wellbeing. It affects how they think, feel and act, and determines how they handle stress, relate to others and make choices. Mental health is important at every stage of life, from childhood and adolescence through adulthood. Good mental health is defined as a state of wellbeing in which individuals realize their own potential, can cope with the normal stresses of life, can work productively and fruitfully, and are able to make a contribution to their communities. It is closely tied to psychosocial wellbeing, which results from the interplay of physical, psychological, cognitive, emotional, social and spiritual aspects that influence a child's or adolescent's ability to grow, learn, socialize, and develop to her or his full potential (UNICEF, 2022).[1]

"We don't pour from empty cups"

Constantly working in changemaker spaces can be deeply fulfilling and rewarding. It offers us a sense of purpose and meaning. It is also true that it comes with potential for high stress, feelings of uncertainty and overwhelm. The challenges we face in our work may sometimes make us feel as though our own feelings are not as important compared to the experiences of the communities around us.

At times, we might find ourselves pushing aside or ignoring our feelings and missing signs of stress such as sustained tiredness or numbness. We may experience fatigue in day-to-day decision making and/or a sense of frustration with our lives. Additionally, we may sometimes even feel disconnected from our families and friends -- feeling unseen or misunderstood in why we feel so deeply about the causes we are involved in. Other times, we might even feel pressured to take on more, as being intentional about work boundaries may come with a sense of perceived judgment from those around us.



In this section, we will invite curiosity around what mental health means to you and what might be a helpful starting point for you in naming, recognizing, and building a toolkit that best responds to challenges specific to your context and realities in addressing mental health stress.

1 United Nations Children's Fund, 'Global Multi Sectoral Operational Framework for Mental Health and Psychosocial Support of Children, Adolescents and Caregivers Across Settings', UNICEF, New York, 2022.

Naming the Uncomfortable: Power & Privilege

Where we come from—the intersecting aspects of our identity including race, gender, class, sexual orientation, ability status, and more—profoundly shape our experiences as changemakers, creating unique challenges and opportunities in our change-making work. These factors determine not only how others perceive and respond to our advocacy efforts, but also which spaces feel accessible, welcoming, or potentially threatening to us. For instance, a young changemaker from a marginalized community may face additional barriers (e.g., language) when speaking truth to power, even when they possess invaluable lived experience that strengthens their message. The varying privileges we hold significantly impact our sense of safety and belonging in different changemaker contexts; some individuals can enter elite policy spaces without question, while others must constantly justify their presence. Furthermore, entrenched power dynamics systematically amplify certain voices while silencing others, determining whose perspectives receive validation and whose concerns get dismissed as unimportant. These realities mean that effective changemaking requires not only passion for a cause, but also a nuanced understanding of how social location and systemic forces influences who gets heard, who faces resistance, and ultimately, how change happens in communities shaped by complex power relationships.

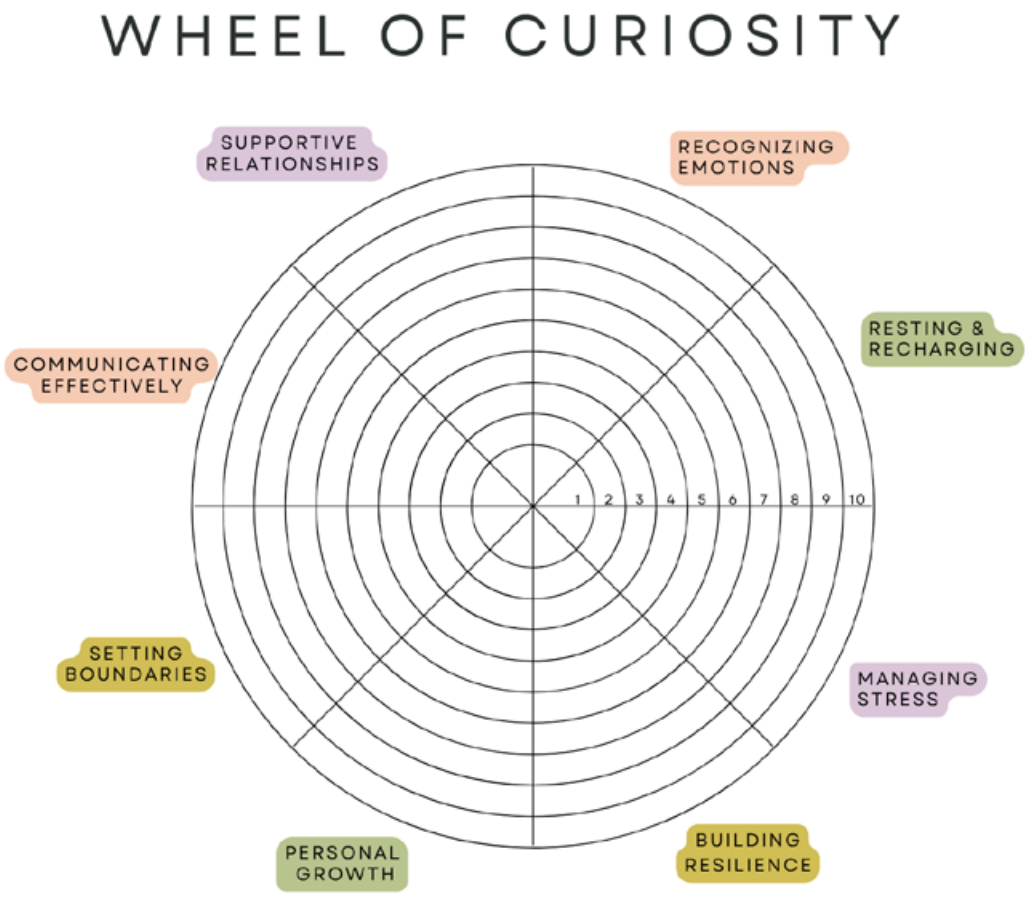
Extension Exercise: Wheel of Curiosity

Take a moment and explore how we feel about our familiarity and comfort in some of the key themes of the training. Each category has a scale from 1-10, 1 being the lowest and 10 being the highest score.

Use this practice to identify the areas you feel confident in and the areas you'd like to grow more.

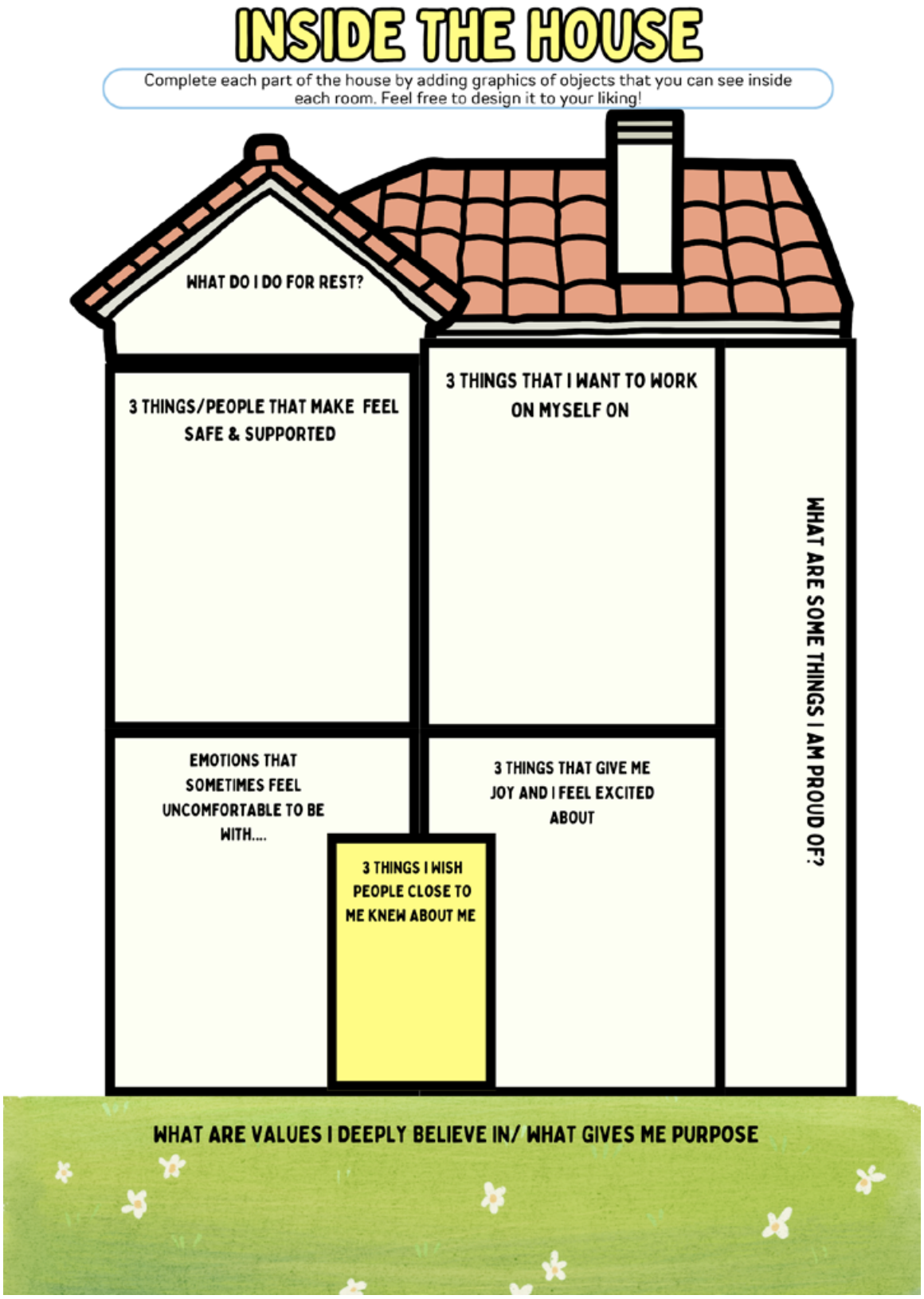
PRIORITY CATEGORIES

NOTES



My Changemaking Foundation

As we explored in the training, our sources of strength and support can come from different spaces, and curiosity about ourselves can help foster a stronger sense of self that helps us build a more resilient and prepared support system around us. This is an activity to help you reflect and name your strengths, needs, and support systems.



My Changemaking Journal: Grounding in Meaning

It can be deeply grounding and empowering to learn more about ourselves and our passions. What makes us do what we do? What shapes our identity and how we view advocacy work?

Take a moment and explore how different aspects of your identity (e.g., gender, race, socioeconomic status, education, etc.) may give you privilege in advocacy settings.

Use this exercise to practice jotting down your reflections.

What does mental health mean to you personally?	
Name 3 ways your mental health impacts your daily life	
What aspects of your identity give you privilege in changemaker spaces?	
What aspects of your identity create barriers?	
How do these factors affect your mental wellbeing when doing advocacy work?	

Gentle Invitations For Reflections

- Young changemakers often experience unique mental health challenges
- Changemaking work can be both fulfilling and depleting
- It is important to recognize your limits is a strength, not a weakness

My Notes

Use this space to jot down some of your favorite coping strategies from the group discussion here, any thoughts or reflections from the session.

.....

.....

.....

Feeling Fluently: Recognizing & Learning About Ourselves

Emotions are signals from our brain that help us understand and respond to situations. They can be positive or negative, mild or intense, or somewhere in between. Intense emotions, however, can sometimes lead to automatic reactions such as “fight, flight, freeze, or fawn.” These reactions may or may not be helpful in the situation.

We can be a student of our emotions & be curious to learn about our needs

Now that we have talked about stress, pressure and our mental health and psychosocial wellbeing as changemakers, let’s explore how emotions can help us. Emotions are like signposts that guide us through our experiences. As activists, we often face high-stress situations where we may feel many different emotions simultaneously while also empathizing with our broader community.

Why Do Emotions Matter?

Emotions are important because they influence our ability to:

- Make decisions.
- Place our experiences in a stressful news or situation.
- Recognize things that are in and outside our control.
- Build and maintain relationships.
- Respond to challenges.
- Understand ourselves and others.

The Power of Naming Emotions

One way to manage emotions is by naming them. When we label an emotion, it helps us step away from automatic reactions. By naming an emotion, we can lessen its intensity and become more thoughtful and self-aware in the situation. Recognizing and understanding our emotions builds awareness, which is essential for responding to them, building our stress tolerance, and helping us advocate for our needs.



Emotions can be triggered and experienced differently (even within ourselves)

Everyone experiences emotions differently, and that's okay!

We can't pretend that emotions always mean the same thing for everyone or every situation. **We have to be the student of our own emotions and study ourselves.** You can experience the same emotion in different ways, at different times – even as the same person.

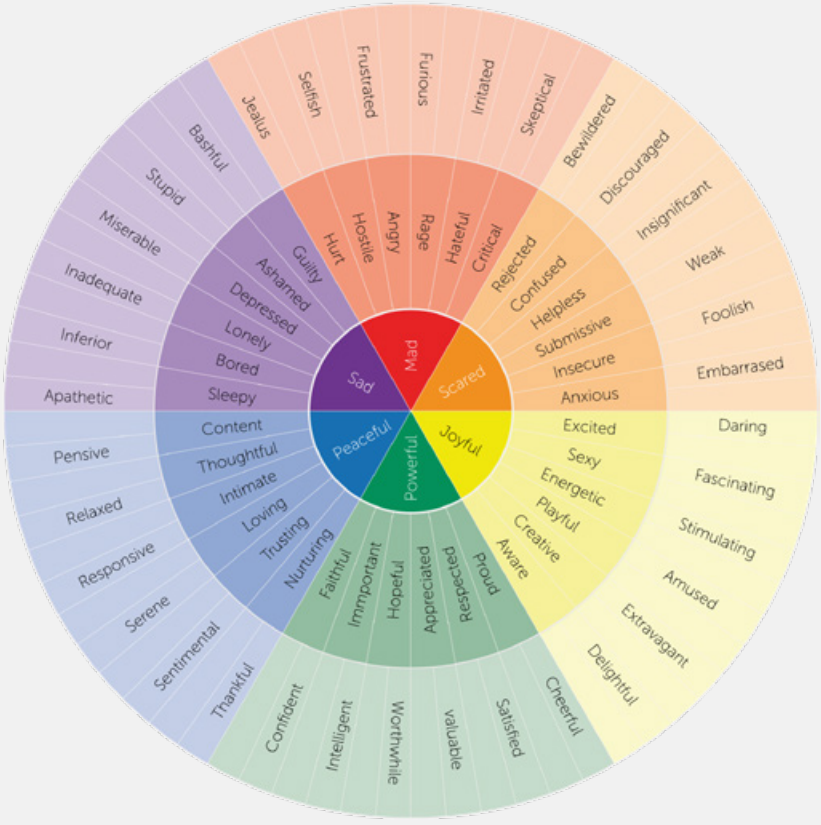
Extension Exercise: The Feelings Wheel

Emotions often come up in response to different situations in our lives. Recognizing and naming them helps us understand how we feel and why.

Use this extension exercise from the training to practice naming emotions.

If any personal situations or big feelings come up while you're working through this exercise, pause and take care of yourself. You can return to the steps later or talk to a trusted adult, mentor, or friend.

1. Read each of the scenarios below.
2. Use the feelings wheel to think about how you might feel if you were in that situation.
3. Write down one or more emotions that best describe your feelings.
4. Find a word on the wheel that best describes your feeling(s).



The Feelings Wheel

Scenario 1:
You worked really hard on a school project, but when you present it, your teacher doesn't seem impressed and gives you a lower grade than expected.

How would this emotion show up on someone's face?	
What would their body language look like?	
What emotion do you think this person would feel?	

Scenario 2:
You receive an unexpected message from a close friend, telling you how much they appreciate you and value your friendship.

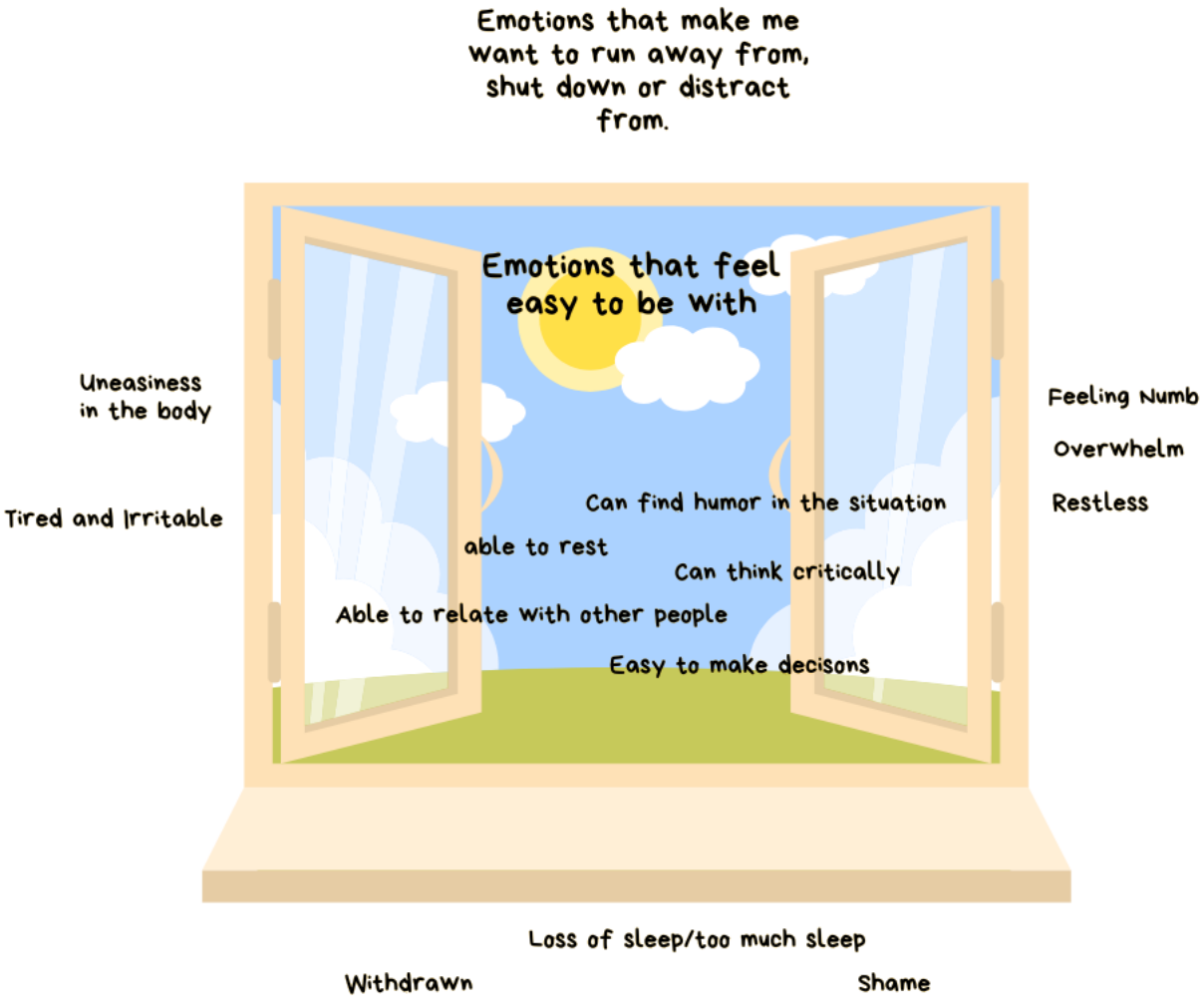
How would this emotion show up on someone's face?	
What would their body language look like?	
What emotion do you think this person would feel?	



My Window of Tolerance

Let's do a visual practice....

Take a moment to visualize a window. This window can be any size and can grow or shrink based on how you're feeling. Everything inside this window represents what you can comfortably respond to without stress. Everything outside might feel scary or overwhelming.



What emotions would you place inside your window?

What emotions would you place outside your window?

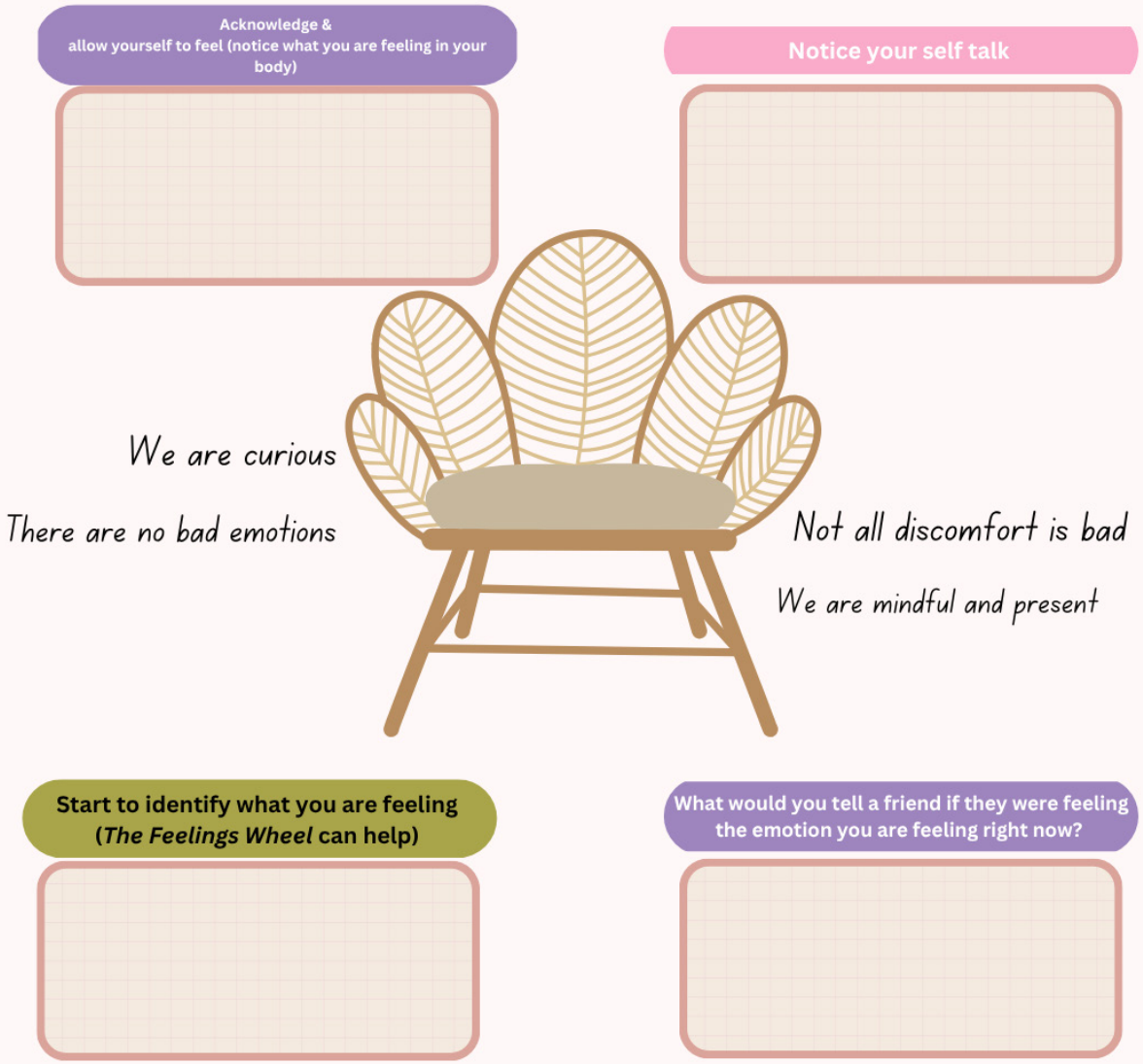
How does naming these emotions help you understand your current needs?

My Changemaking Journal

- How do I view emotions?
- Do I sometimes see certain emotions as “good or bad? Does it change how I process them?



If I were to reimagine **sitting with my emotions**, what could that look like?
Take a moment, and follow the nudges mentioned below;



My Notes

Use this space to jot down some of your favorite coping strategies from the group discussion here, any thoughts or reflections from the session.

.....

.....

.....

The Emotional Compass: Navigating Stress in Daily Life

Stress is a natural physiological and psychological response that occurs when we face an actual or perceived threat, known as a "stressor" (Selye, 1956). It presents as feelings of worry or discomfort, typically arising from specific events, situations, or a combination of circumstances.

We trust our bodies to guide us

Climate change? Political crises? Growing uncertainty? It all feels too much, doesn't it? Almost like weight being placed on our bodies.

Well, that might be stress – demands placed on our nervous systems and bodies by external events or personal experiences. It's like an alarm telling us something needs support and attention.

Is all stress bad? Just like everything else in moderation - no. Everybody experiences stress, and sometimes, stress can be a great motivator, helping us perform better at work, school or in our daily lives. For instance, feeling stressed about a speech or webinar might drive us to prepare better. But when tension exceeds what our bodies can handle, or when we experience too much stress or for too long, it brings overwhelm or stuckness (our fight-or-flight response). Overwhelming stress is an unhelpful form of stress.

How does stress show up? Our bodies speak to us through tight shoulders causing headaches, upset stomachs, changing appetites, disrupted sleep, racing hearts, and even skin breakouts. These signals aren't random—they're warning lights indicating your emotions need attention. When you notice these physical signs, it's your cue to pause, breathe deeply, and give yourself some extra care.



Extension Exercise: The Body Stress Map

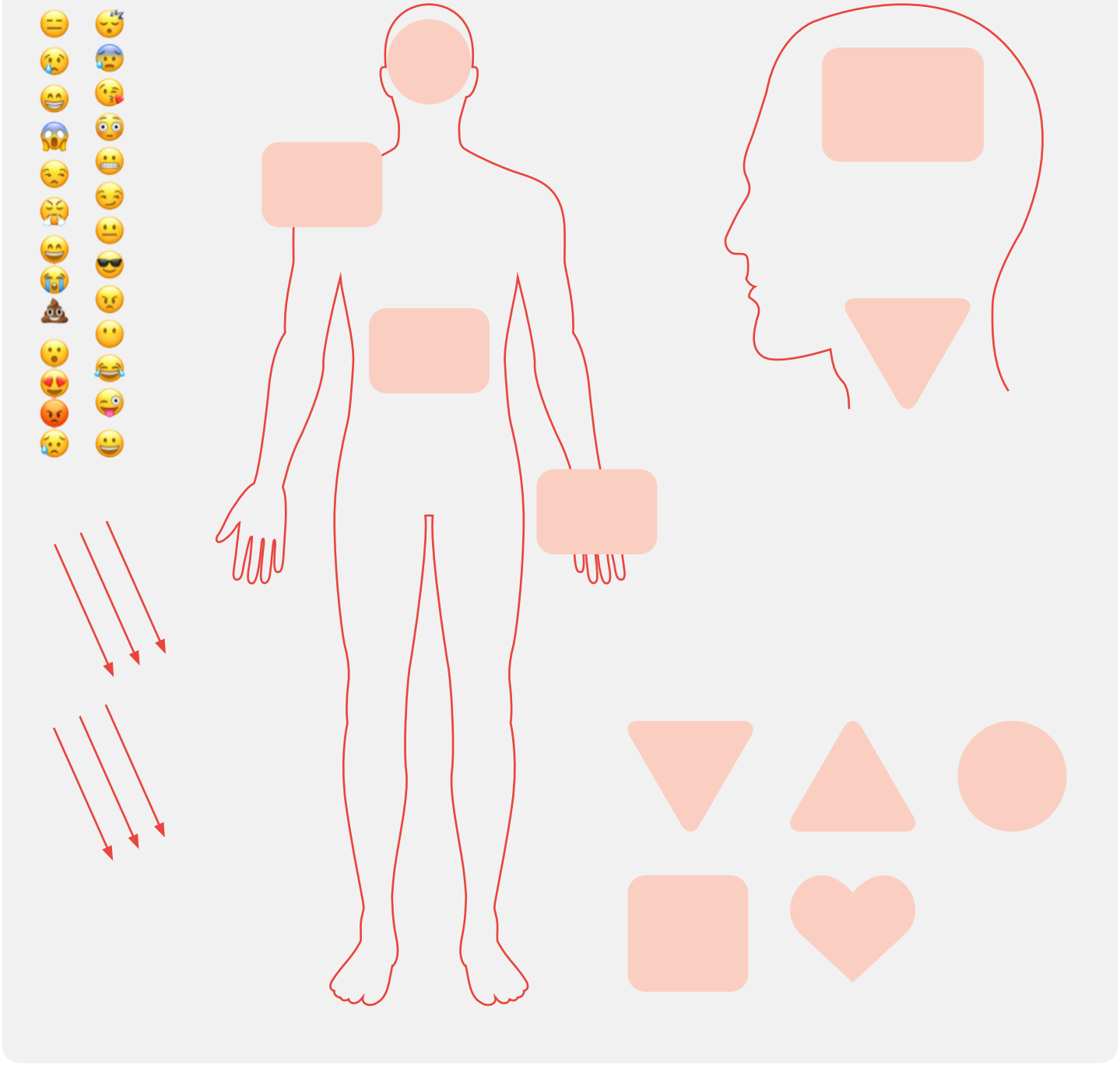
Let's take a look at where stress shows up in your body;

In this activity, you'll create a visual map of how stress affects your body. First, select the blank body template provided.

1. Get comfortable: Sit or lie down, whichever position feels good to you right now.
2. Close your eyes and gently place your hands over your belly.
3. Take a large breath in and hold your breath. Imagine your breath reaching every corner inside your body.
4. Exhale slowly. Visualize the breath slowly moving out of your belly button, little by little.
5. What emotions are you feeling right now? If you feel comfortable, you can name them out loud.
6. Where do you feel this emotion in your body? How does it feel? For example - is there a body part that aches, hurts, or feels fuzzy?
7. Let's change the text to bold, write down the specific stressors you experience in your changemaking work (like tight deadlines, difficult conversations, or feeling overwhelmed).
8. Next, using italics, write or draw the physical and emotional feelings these stressors cause inside different parts of your body—perhaps a racing heart, tight shoulders, or a queasy stomach. Remember those emotion words from our feelings wheel activity? They can help you name what you're experiencing! If you have time, use the arrows to connect each external stressor to the internal feelings it creates. This visual connection helps you understand how your unique body responds to stress and where you might focus your self-care efforts.
9. Repeat this as many times as you need, naming different emotions and where and how you feel them. Mark them into the drawing below.



What does stress feel like in our bodies?



Does anything stand out to you in your responses?

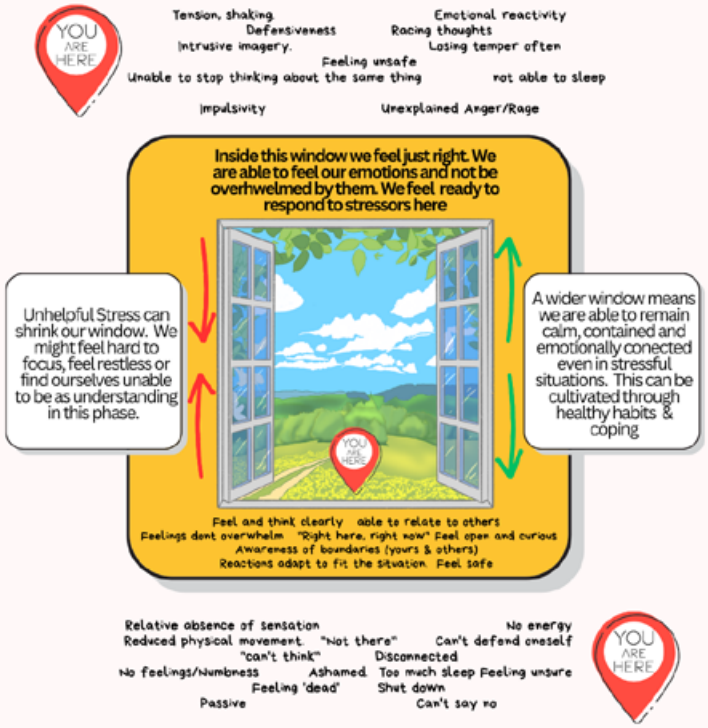
What are some of the stressors that contribute to that emotion showing up? Do they generally present more often than some other stressors?

How does that emotion impact you over time? Notice if you feel strongly towards a particular feeling a stressor might invite? (e.g.: I hate that I feel angry all the time)

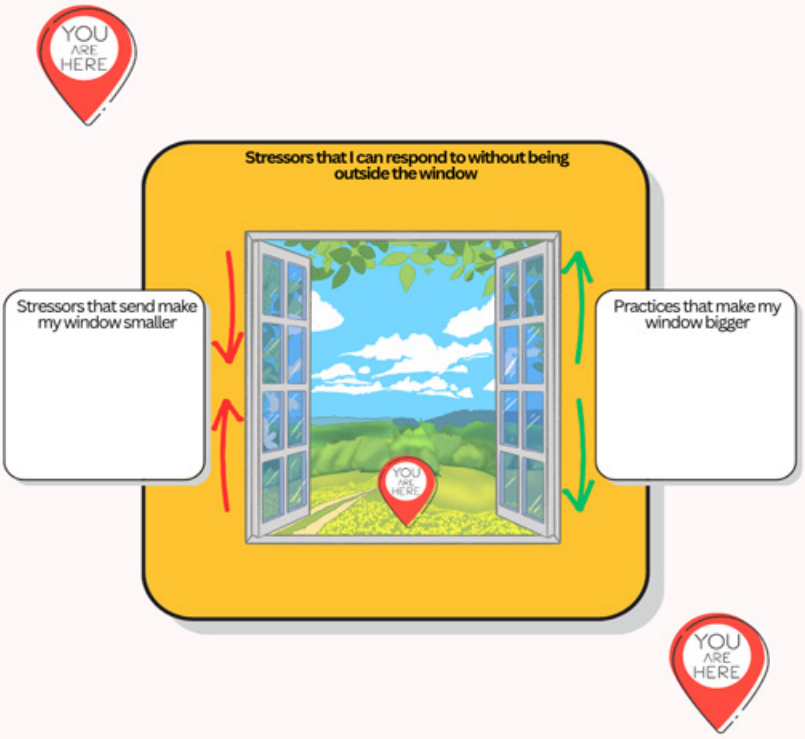
What would you like to let this sensation and emotion know right now? Is there anything you can recognize that might feel supportive to this experience?

Practice: My Window of Tolerance and Stress

Remember the window from the last chapter? We learnt that this window could expand and contract, it is a great reminder for us that our stress can greatly impact our capacity emotionally, physically and socially. Let's take some time to learn more about your own window and how it might shift, grow and evolve.[2]



Now take a moment to fill in feedback for what your current window looks like;



2 Siegel, D. J. (1999). *The developing mind: Toward a neurobiology of interpersonal experience.* Guilford Press.

My Changemaking Journal: Listening to My Body

As you spend time being more curious about your body and how it tells you about your emotional state, take a moment to thank it for containing all these intense emotions for you, sustaining you, and helping you navigate day-to-day life, especially when it is hard. Can you think of any 2 things you would like to thank your body for today?

If your emotions today were weather patterns, what would they be? Describe the storms, sunny periods, or changing conditions you've experienced. What external and internal factors contributed to these emotional weather shifts, and how did they affect your stress levels?

What are some stressors that were surprising or unexpected for you? Have you noticed any physical experience (muscle tension, digestive issues, fatigue, etc) that is recurrent when stressed?

What are 2 things that help you come back inside your 'window' when you are stressed?

Is there anything that reduces significantly in your behavior when you are stressed? (patience, empathy, concentration, problem solving skills)?

What are 2 things you notice more of in your body and behavior when you are stressed?

My Notes

Use this space to jot down some of your favorite coping strategies from the group discussion here, any thoughts or reflections from the session.



Staying Steady: Coping with Pressure and Stress

Coping strategies are the many ways that you could choose to manage the pressure you face. Responding to pressure is an important skill that we can develop to help us manage stress.

Not all discomfort is bad, sometimes it tells us of our needs

Stress often brings negative thoughts that can cloud our judgment and emotions. These thoughts can keep us stuck in a loop of worry or anxiety. If your thoughts accurately reflect a dangerous or unjust reality, it's important to acknowledge them and seek the support needed rather than simply trying to reframe. Other times, reframing can be a simple yet powerful tool to help you break that cycle and regain control.

Aspect	Healthy Stress	Chronic Stress
Duration	Short-term with clear endpoint Temporary challenges Followed by recovery periods	• Long-term and persistent • Ongoing without adequate relief • No clear resolution in sight
Physical Effects	Better focus and energy Improved memory for studying Stronger immune system Enhanced athletic performance	• Frequent headaches and muscle tension • Stomach issues and trouble sleeping • Getting sick more often • Constant tiredness and fatigue
Mental/Emotional Impact	Feels exciting and motivating • Sense of purpose and growth Challenge feels manageable Looking forward to outcomes	• Constant worry and irritability • Hard to focus on schoolwork • Forgetting things more often • Feeling overwhelmed all the time
Behavioral Changes	More motivated to try new things Staying engaged with activities Keeping up with friends Using healthy ways to cope	• Pulling away from friends and family • Eating too much or too little • Turning to unhealthy habits • Skipping self-care and hobbies
Control & Perception	Feel like you can handle it • Sense of control over the situation Clear benefits and purpose Stays within your comfort zone	• Feels too big to handle • Loss of control over your life • Can't see any benefits • Way outside your comfort zone
Common Sources	Trying out for teams or clubs • Preparing for exams or presentations Learning new skills or hobbies Starting at a new school	• Family financial stress • Political Uncertainty • Academic pressure that never stops • Major family changes or exposure to or witnessing trauma • Climate change

Letting Go of Negative Thinking: The Power of Re-framing

When we focus on the worst-case scenarios, stress can feel overwhelming. The key is recognizing that our thoughts don't always reflect reality. By learning to reframe, you can change your perspective, making stressful situations feel more manageable.

Letting go of our negative thoughts or at least adding in some more positive thoughts might not make a problem go away. But it can help bring **your stress to a manageable level.**

Reframing is not about denying stress—it's about making space for more balanced, positive thoughts. By shifting your focus from negativity to empowerment, you can handle life's challenges with more confidence, calm, and resilience. A powerful practice in helping you sustain reframing practices could be using physical movement as a means to build resilience. When we engage in movement—whether it's a brisk walk, yoga session, or dance break—we naturally redirect our minds away from negative thinking patterns while releasing endorphins that improve our mood. Beyond the immediate relief, establishing consistent daily routines around sleep, eating, and exercise creates a sense of control when life feels overwhelming or unpredictable. These foundational habits act as anchors during stressful periods, providing structure and stability that help us navigate challenges more effectively. By maintaining reasonable patterns of rest, nourishment, and movement, we build resilience against stress and create a solid foundation for overall mental health.

By allowing yourself to think of different perspectives, we can adopt a more empowering approach in responding to challenging experiences in life.

If you are in a context of acute distress, such as an exposure to or witnessing of a traumatic event or circumstances like a humanitarian or displacement setting, this might not be your go to strategy. Similarly, in cases of violence, discrimination or systemic challenges, this coping strategy might not be suitable.

Ask Yourself Some Key Questions

Challenging negative thoughts starts by asking yourself the right questions. This simple step helps you shift to a more balanced view:

- Am I only thinking about the worst things that could happen?
- What are some other possibilities of what could happen?
- Is this true?
- Is my thinking based on facts?
- What is a time that I have overcome something similar?
- How might a good friend think about this situation?



Extension Exercise: Re-framing Negative Self-Talk

In this activity, we'll explore how to identify and challenge limiting thoughts, and assess our reality to potentially replace them with alternate perspectives. Remember, this isn't about ignoring difficulties—it's about giving yourself the space to respond from a place of strength and self-compassion.

Use this exercise to reframe negative self-talk

If any personal situations or big feelings come up while you're working through this exercise, pause and take care of yourself. You can return to the steps later or talk to a trusted adult, mentor, or friend.

1. Read each of the scenarios below.
2. Fill in the last column with what you could say instead to reframe. Use the re-framing questions to help.
3. If you feel comfortable, add your own scenario in the last row.

Scenario	Negative Self-Talk	What Could Be Said Instead?
Making a Presentation	"I'm afraid I'll come across as unprepared or boring, and people might think I don't know what I'm talking about."	
Making a Mistake in a Relationship	"I can't believe I said or did that; they must think I'm a terrible friend/partner. I probably ruined things between us."	
[Add Your Own]		



Practice: Window of Tolerance and Self-Talk

Understanding self-talk and the window of tolerance provides powerful insights into emotional regulation. By cultivating awareness, practicing compassionate self-talk, and developing emotional regulation skills, individuals can expand their capacity to manage stress, respond to challenges, and maintain emotional balance.

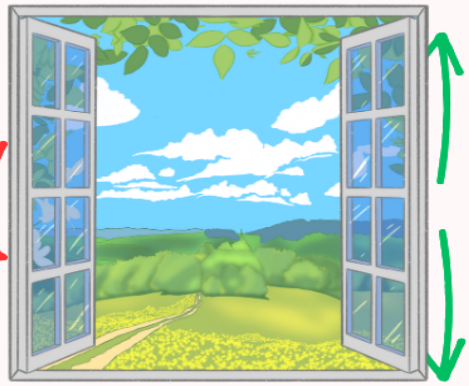
Remember, emotional regulation is a skill that can be learned and improved with practice, patience. Let's take a moment to be curious about our self talk and visualize how the way we talk to ourselves grows, shrinks or sustains this window.

Take a moment to think of words and phrases that invite discomfort for you. (refer to the emotions and stress activities)

Notice how you speak to yourself when feeling frustrated/angry?

Take a minute to visualize if your window grows or shrinks when in this space

Write down phrases and words that you can identify here:



Take a moment to think of words and phrases that help you feel more grounded (refer to the emotions and stress activities)

Notice how you speak to yourself when feeling overwhelmed

Take a minute to visualize what your window looks like when you offer affirmations or support through helpful self talk

Write down phrases and words that you can identify here:

When you are inside your window and feel like you are able to respond to pressure and stress what does the self talk sound like?

Notice how your body is when you speak kindly to yourself?

Take a minute to visualize if your window grows or shrinks when in this space

Write down phrases and words that you can identify here:

My Changemaking Journal

- Do I engage in a lot of negative self-talk? How does it make it feel when I do?
- What is one thing that I could do differently to interrupt that negative self-talk?

My Notes

Use this space to jot down some of your favorite coping strategies from the group discussion here, any thoughts or reflections from the session.

Small Steps, Strong Foundations: Building Healthy Habits

Healthy habits are actions and practices that include physical, mental, and social dimensions of our lives. These habits are defined as consistent, positive behaviors that promote optimal growth, development, and resilience, including balanced nutrition, regular physical activity, adequate sleep, emotional regulation, good hygiene practices, safe social interactions, and responsible use of technology. These are dynamic, culturally sensitive practices that empower us to make informed choices about our health, protect ourselves from risks, and develop the skills necessary for comprehensive personal development.

We Welcome Persistence Over Perfection

Habits are the building blocks that transform our intentions into action. Each habit is a powerful tool that can either support or challenge our mental health and psychosocial well-being. The key is awareness—understanding how our daily practices impact our emotional resilience and ability to create meaningful change.

Creating impactful habits is about being compassionate with ourselves and curious about our emotional, physical and social needs. Focusing on developing practices that align with our values, protect our emotional boundaries, and provide the strength needed for our advocacy work while juggling other parts of our lives such as school and family.

Remember, habit formation is a journey of growth, not perfection—small, consistent steps can make a profound difference in maintaining your mental health and personal effectiveness.

Persistence is a great value belief to hold to foster resilience. It says it's about showing up, with imperfections and curiosity. For example the The 80/20 method, also known as the Pareto Principle, suggests that roughly 80% of results come from 20% of efforts, making it a powerful tool for embracing persistence over perfection. Instead of trying to perfect every detail, this approach encourages you to identify and focus on the most impactful activities that drive the majority of your outcomes.

Practice: The Habit Chain

Of course, habits are important, and we "should" be diligent with them. However, sometimes it can be hard to maintain habits even when we have the intention to do so. Something that can help is to see things we can add to what we are already doing instead of aiming for something completely new and not a part of our routine. So, for instance, if you are on a mission to eat healthier, think of one thing you can add to your meals that you are currently eating.

Step 1: Think of a chain, where you can link a new habit to an existing one.

Example: If you already brush your teeth every morning, you can link a new habit by practicing deep breathing exercises immediately afterwards.

1. What are three small, daily habits you already do without thinking?

2. What are three new habits you'd like to integrate into your routine to support your mental well-being?

Step 2: Identifying Personal Mental Health Needs

Before we start, it's essential to identify areas where you need support. Consider your current stressors, energy levels, and emotional well-being.

- List three challenges you face in maintaining your mental health and psychosocial well-being.

- Identify habits that could help address these challenges. Example: If you want to improve your sleep cycle, finding ways to avoid doom scrolling before bed can be a helpful starting point, such as by keeping your phone in a different room an hour before bed, or putting limits on select apps on your phone, if possible

Step 3: Creating a Habit link

Let's try this flow:
Formula: After [current habit], I will [new habit].
Example: After I wake up, I will have one glass of water.

Your Turn:

Identify an existing habit: .....

Choose a new habit to stack: .....

Create your habit stacking statement: After I ..... I will .....

Step 4: Habit Links for Mental Health

Try these mental health-focused habit-stacking examples:

- **After I wake up**, I will take three deep breaths before checking my phone.

- **After I finish my schoolwork**, I will go for a five-minute walk.

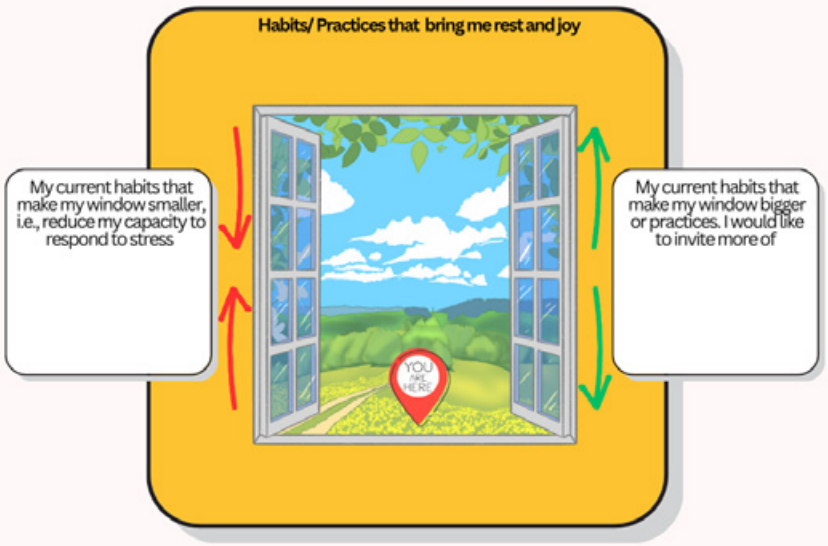
- **After I have lunch,** I will text a friend to check in.

Reflection:

- How do these small habits impact your daily mood?
- Which habit stack feels easiest to maintain?

Practice: My Window of Tolerance and Habits

We've already explored how stress and emotions can impact our window of tolerance. Now, let's look at how our everyday habits can support and expand our ability to handle life's challenges. Your window of tolerance is personal. What works for someone else might not work for you, and that's completely okay. The goal is to discover what helps YOU feel more balanced and resilient. This is not about adding more pressure or creating another "should" in your life. It's about gentle exploration and self-understanding. Some days will feel easier, some harder – and that's the natural rhythm of being human. Remember, developing and maintaining healthy habits is a continuous process, and in many ways, is a wonderful act of self-care.



Notice your responses here, do you see any potential habits you might want to do more or less of and how it might impact your mental wellbeing:

My Changemaking Journal: Habits & Health

What Habits Nourish Me? Reflect on the habits that genuinely support your mental well-being. Consider:

Which daily habits make you feel more centered?	What small actions consistently lift your mood or reduce your stress?	How do these habits contribute to your sense of emotional balance?

Invitation: Take time to acknowledge and celebrate these supportive habits, recognizing that they are acts of self-care and resilience.

Where Do My Habits Challenge My Mental Health?
Explore the habits that might be subtly draining your emotional energy:

Are there patterns or routines that consistently leave you feeling depleted?	Which habits might be coping mechanisms that no longer serve you?	How do these habits impact your window of tolerance?

Invitation: Approach this reflection with curiosity and compassion, not judgment. The goal is awareness, not criticism.

If I Could Gently Shift One Habit to Support My Mental Health, What Might It Be? Imagine a small, manageable change:

What's one habit you could introduce or modify that feels supportive?	How might this shift create more space for your emotional well-being?	What resources or support might help you make this change?

Invitation: Focus on possibility and potential, remembering that meaningful change often comes from small, consistent steps.

My Notes

Use this space to jot down some of your favorite coping strategies from the group discussion here, any thoughts or reflections from the session.

.....

.....

.....

Say It Like You Mean It: Communicating and Setting Boundaries

A **boundary** is a limit set to protect one's well-being, defining what is acceptable in relationships, behaviors, and interactions. It helps maintain personal safety, respect, and balance in various aspects of life.

Boundaries invite structure, not distance.

As a changemaker, your work can be demanding, and it's easy to pour all your energy into caring for others. **But you matter too**, and protecting your own well-being is just as important as the causes you champion. Setting and maintaining healthy boundaries helps you stay balanced, focused, and energized, ensuring you can keep making a meaningful impact without burning out.

A boundary is a firm limit you set to protect your well-being, while a request is something you ask for, with room for negotiation or acceptance.

Boundaries are the limits you set to protect your emotional, mental, and physical health. They help you safeguard your energy, ensuring you can continue your work sustainably. Setting boundaries doesn't make you selfish—it makes you stronger and more effective as a changemaker. It's a crucial skill that empowers you to prioritize yourself while still being there for others.

It is important to name what boundaries are not.

- They aren't ultimatums or threats, dismissing experiences of other people, avoiding accountability, or being rude or controlling someone else.
- Boundaries aren't one-size-fits-all. Each person has unique needs, and your boundaries will evolve based on your personal experiences and your changemaking journey.

Here are some common types of boundaries that can support your well-being:



Extension Exercise: Boundary Setting in Action

In this activity, you'll explore a boundary scenario to reflect on how to protect your well-being while staying effective in your changemaking work. Consider the example and think about how you can apply similar boundaries in your own life.

Use this exercise to think about different types of boundaries and how to set them.

If any personal situations or big feelings come up while you're working through this exercise, pause and take care of yourself. You can return to the steps later or talk to a trusted adult, mentor, or friend.

After reading the scenario, use the boundary table to name the boundary, describe the type of boundary, and write whether you have utilized a similar boundary in the past. Think about how this type of boundary has shown up for you in your changemaking work.

Jasmine - Mental Health Boundaries in Changemaking

Jasmine, a young changemaker involved in policy reform, often receives urgent requests to attend late-night strategy meetings or respond to late emails about ongoing projects. To maintain her mental health and prevent burnout, she sets a boundary by stating, "I'm unavailable for work-related tasks after 7 PM, but I will respond first thing the next morning." By establishing this boundary, Jasmine ensures she maintains a healthy work-life balance while still contributing to her advocacy work.

Boundary name	Type of boundary	How has this boundary shown up for you?



Practice: Boundary Self-Assessment

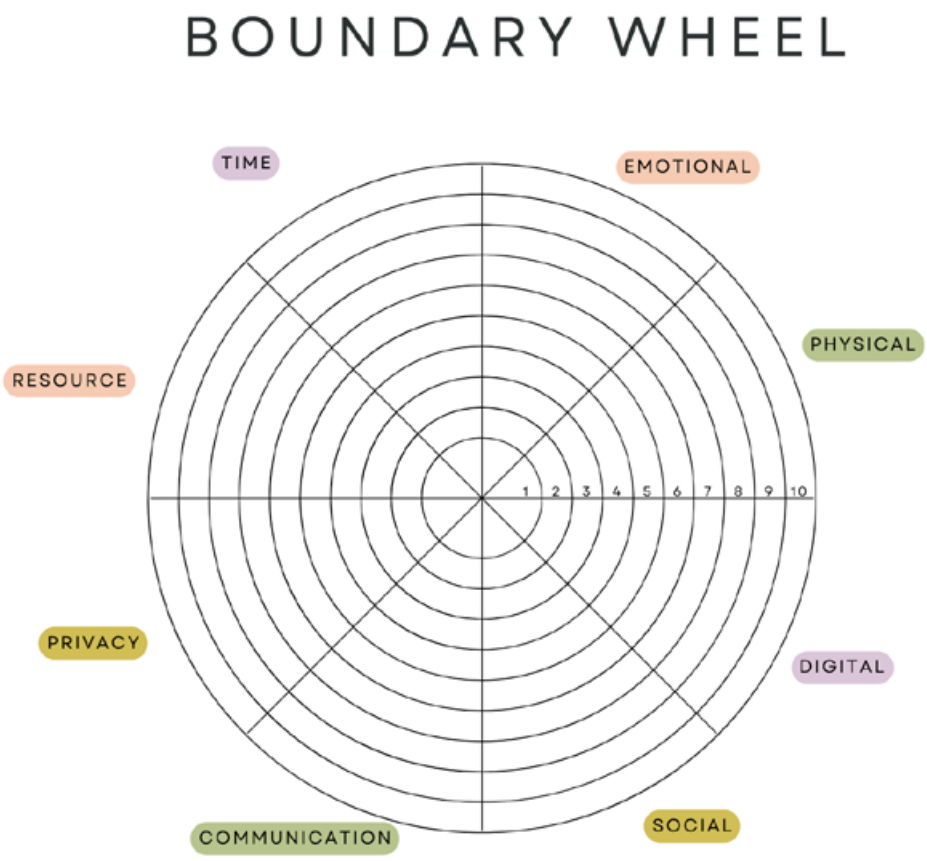
Reflect on different types of boundaries—emotional, physical, time, energy, and relational. For each area on the boundary wheel, rate yourself on a scale from 1 to 10:

1 = My boundaries are very unclear or often crossed
10 = My boundaries are consistently clear, respected, and well-maintained

Be honest with yourself—this is about self-awareness, not perfection. Once you've rated each area, look at where your boundaries feel strongest and where they may need a little more attention or support. Use this as a starting point for reflection and growth.

PRIORITY CATEGORIES

NOTES



My Changemaking Journal

- Can you think of a time when you set a boundary or two?
- Which types of boundaries would you like to spend more time thinking about and creating for yourself?
- How does it feel to set boundaries?

My Notes

Use this space to jot down some of your favorite boundary-setting strategies from the group discussion here, and any thoughts or reflections from the session.

Solving Problems Like a Changemaker

In this space, we'll explore something that's super real for all of us: **problems**. We all face them—some small, some big, some confusing or frustrating. Learning how to **problem solve** is one of the most powerful things you can do for your mental health.

Some Problems Are Complex—And That's Okay

There are moments when the problems we face don't have simple or immediate solutions. In situations involving violence, injustice, or systems that feel stacked against us, problem-solving might not feel easy—or even possible—right away. That's okay. The goal is not to have the "answer" every time, but the awareness around what is in our control and what isn't.

You can still care for yourself, ask for support, and explore steps that help you cope or regain some sense of agency. Asking for help is a sign of strength, particularly in difficult situations. Just like any skill, problem-solving is something we practice, not something we perfect. Focusing on coping with the uncertainty of a problem that might not have a clear solution, using some of the skills that we practiced before, such as doing things we enjoy and taking time to relax.

Managing Problems One Step at a Time

Here are six key steps that can help you manage tough situations in a clear, thoughtful way. These steps won't solve every problem, but they *will* help you better understand what you're feeling, what you want, and what actions might be possible.



Extension Exercise: Using the 6 Step Problem-Solving Process

Let's practice solving a problem using the six-step process. Read the scenario and use the steps below to explore how you might manage this scenario.

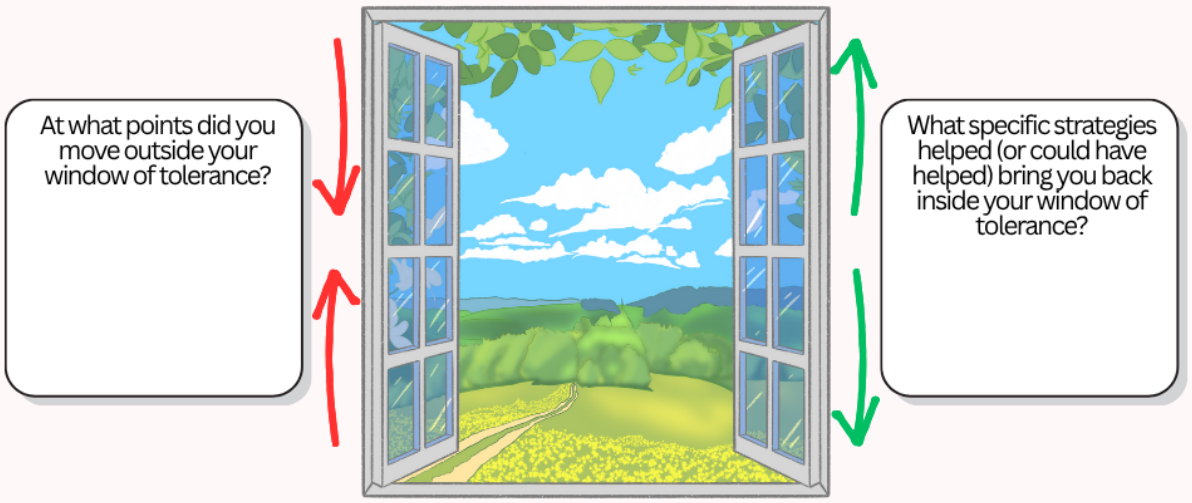
If any personal situations or big feelings come up while you're working through this exercise, pause and take care of yourself. You can return to the steps later or talk to a trusted adult, mentor, or friend.

Scenario A Group Project Gone Wrong: You've been working on a group project at school, and one of your teammates submitted the final version without including your part or checking with you. You feel frustrated and left out. You want to stay on good terms with your group but also want to speak up for yourself.

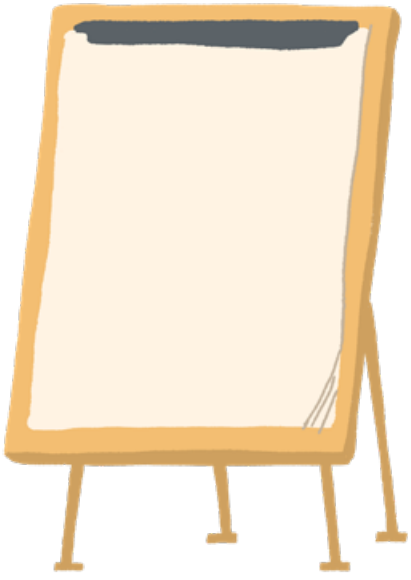
Steps	Questions to Ask Yourself	Thoughts & Actions
1. Identify the problem and how you feel about it	What is the problem and how do you feel about the problem?	
2. Identify what your goal is	What might be a realistic goal that would help you in this situation?	
3. Identify what you might need to reach your goal	What information or support might you need to help you reach your goal?	
4. Identify what obstacles you might face in reaching your goal	Are there challenges that you might face in achieving this goal?	
5. Identify some possible solutions and actions	What are some solutions and actions that can help you deal with the problem and possible obstacles?	
6. Take action	What solutions do you feel might be best to try first?	

Practice: Mapping Our Comfort Zone

Let's revisit the window of tolerance. So far, we have learned about what our window looks like when we are stressed, contained, or under pressure. Let's take a minute to explore the following prompts, right your answers in the window:
Recall a recent problem you faced and track your location in the window (above, inside, or below) throughout the experience.



How did this affect your problem-solving approach and decisions?



My Changemaker Journal

- How do you usually problem-solve when you run into challenges as a changemaker?
- Are there strategies that you prefer over others? Why?
- How does it feel to go through the six-step problem-solving strategy?

My Notes

Use this space to jot down some of your favorite problem-solving strategies from the group discussion here, any thoughts or reflections from the session.

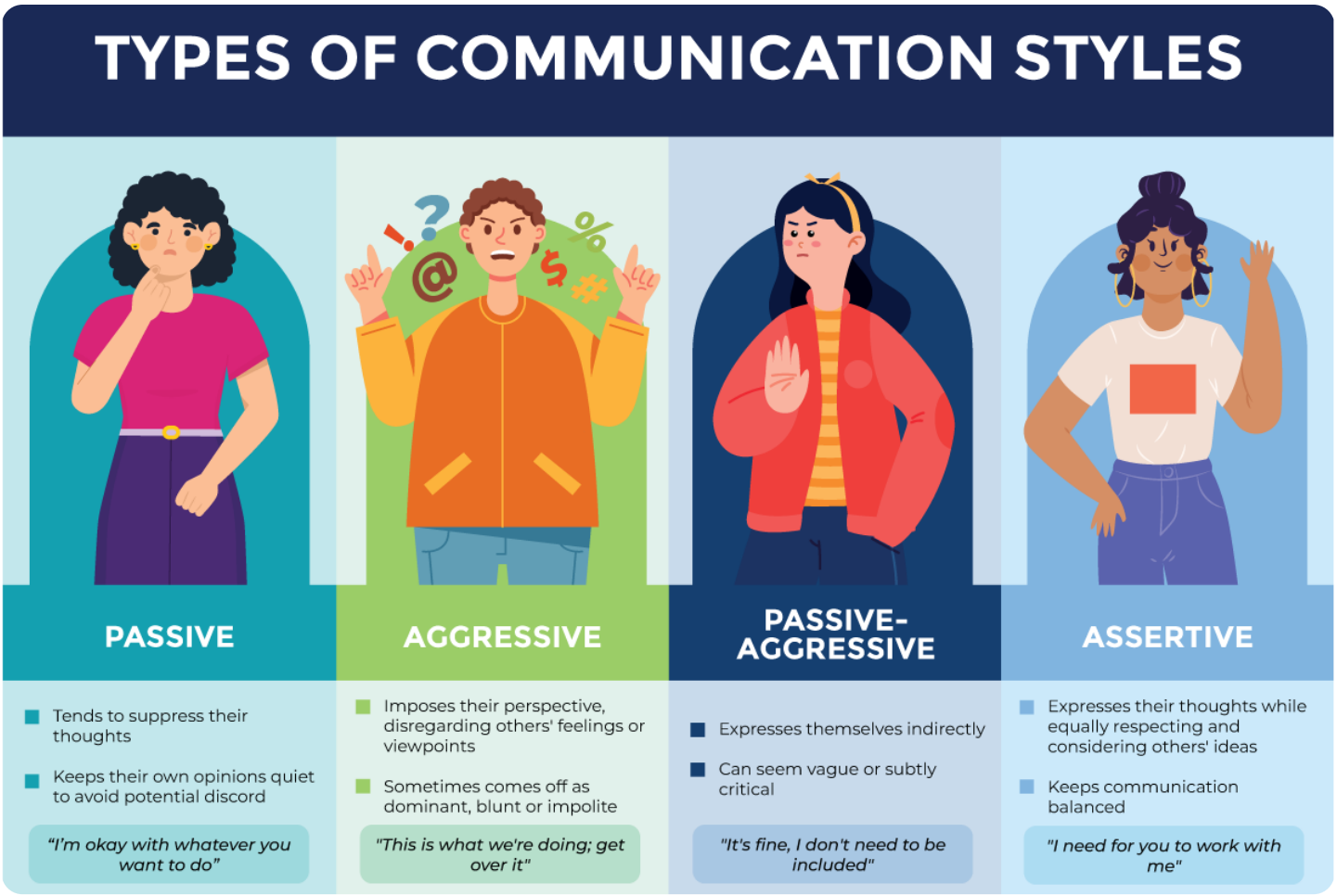
Standing Firm, Speaking Kind: Communicating Effectively

Communication styles are distinct patterns in how people express themselves and interact with others. These patterns include verbal elements (word choice, tone), nonverbal cues (body language, facial expressions), and interaction tendencies (listening habits, turn-taking). Effective communicators adapt their style based on context, audience, and goals. Understanding different communication styles helps improve relationships, reduce misunderstandings, and enhance collaboration.

We Lead with Curiosity, Not Fear

The way we communicate shapes our relationships, influences how others perceive us, and impacts our ability to advocate effectively. Communication styles are unique patterns of expression that reflect our personalities, backgrounds, and emotional states. As youth advocates, recognizing our own communication tendencies and learning to adapt them can dramatically enhance our effectiveness when supporting others, collaborating with teams, or speaking up for change.

Understanding different communication styles isn't about labeling yourself or others as "good" or "bad" communicators. Rather, it's about developing awareness of how we naturally express ourselves and gaining flexibility to adjust our approach when needed. We'll explore various communication patterns in the next section, discover how to maintain authenticity while developing versatile communication styles that serve both our advocacy goals and our own mental wellbeing.



©One Call Can Change Your Life" Mentalhealthhotline.org

Practice: My Communication Compass

Based on our learnings from the training, let's look at what might be our own communication style. It will help you identify your natural communication tendencies and develop awareness of how your style shifts in different contexts.

Take a moment to reflect on how you typically communicate in these different situations. For each scenario, write a few sentences describing how you might feel for the following cues.

If any personal situations or big feelings come up while you're working through this exercise, pause and take care of yourself. You can return to the steps later or talk to a trusted adult, mentor, or friend.

Scenario/ Response	Speaking with a close friend about something that upset you	Presenting an idea to a group (class, club, or organization)	Advocating for someone who needs support with authority figure	Navigating disagreements with someone who has different views
What words and tone you typically use				
Your body language and facial expressions				
How much you speak versus listen				
How you feel internally during the interaction				
Naming power imbalances in the situation				

Pattern Finder: Review what you wrote. Circle or highlight words that appear repeatedly across scenarios. Then answer:

Situations I felt empowered In	When do I notice being more assertive?	Some communication challenges that I face a lot	My strength in communication contexts

Growth Opportunity: Choose one challenging communication scenario and:

Describe current approach and feelings	Identify one small improvement shift	Write a practice script with this adjustment	Reflect on potential impact

Practice: 'I' Matters

"I" statements are a simple way of speaking that will help you avoid this trap by reducing feelings of blame and being more honest in your communication. A helpful "I" statement takes responsibility for one's own feelings, while tactfully addressing a problem.

"I feel **[emotion word]** when **[explanation]**." (Check out the emotion wheel if you are finding yourself stuck here)

- "I feel..." is followed with an emotion word, such as "angry", "hurt", or "worried".
- Careful wording won't help if your voice still sounds blaming. Use a soft and even tone.
- In your explanation, gently describe how the other person's actions affect you.

Examples

Blaming: "You never call me. I guess we just won't talk anymore."

"I" Statement : "I feel hurt when you go so long without calling. I'm afraid you don't care."

Let's Practice!

Practice Scenario: A friend always cancels plans at the last minute. Recently, you were waiting for them at a restaurant, when they called to say they couldn't make it.

"I" Statement:

Scenario: You are working on a group project, and one member is not completing their portion. You have repeatedly had to finish their work.

"I" Statement:

Scenario: Your advocacy group leader keeps dumping new work on you, with little instruction, and not enough time. Despite working diligently, you're weeks behind.

"I" Statement:

My Changemaking Journal: Taking Space

Power & Communication

- How does your communication change when speaking with authority figures? (voice, posture, words)
- How does this affect your message's impact?

Learning From Experience

- Recall a successful changemaking moment: What approach worked? How did it feel in your body?
- Remember a challenging changemaking attempt: What barriers affected you? What tools might have helped?
- What does your authentic voice sound and feel like at your most effective?

My Notes

Use this space to jot down some of your favorite problem-solving strategies from the group discussion here, any thoughts or reflections from the session.

My Wellbeing Toolbox

My Care Box

Maintaining your mental wellness as a changemaker is an ongoing process, so you will continuously evaluate whether you need help, and what type of help you need, as you move forward in your journey. Mental health is a very personal journey, so the places or people you would go to when you are in distress or need help would also be personal.

This is a space for you to create your own personal self-care plan and resource list. Here you can include names of people you trust, allies you can approach, places and spaces you can visit, as well as calming exercises you can do when you feel overwhelmed.

Keep these lists close and refer to them when you are feeling low

Three peers I trust and can reach out to if I am in need.

Name	Contact information	Notes

Three adults I trust and can reach out to if I am in need.

Name	Contact information	Notes

Three young people I can connect with who do work similar to mine or who study the same subjects.

Name	Contact information	Notes

Three spaces that make me feel calm and safe.

1	
2	
3	

Three activities that I find fun and enjoyable.

1	
2	
3	

Three calming exercises/movements that I can use.

1	
2	
3	

Three people in my life who help me feel good.

1	
2	
3	

Three helpful affirmations that make me feel good.

1	
2	
3	

Additional resources in my community.

(Find these before you need them)

Social Media: .....

Support Groups: .....

Websites: .....



Letter to Myself

In the message, write the date 10 years from today. Be sure to write something you are proud of, something that encourages you and reminds you about the resources you have within you.

In your letter, you might want to add:

- What goals, skills and practices you've taken from our time together and what you might still want to develop?
- How you are feeling at the moment about your friendships and family and how you hope those relationships will be 10 years from now?
- Your biggest challenges right now and what you hope to learn or get better at over the next 10 years.
- What kind of difference you hope to make in your community and in the world?

My Notes

Use this space to jot down some of your favorite coping strategies from the group discussion here, any thoughts or reflections from the session.

unicef

for every child

